about the Navy had been running blockades since the days of John Paul Jones.'

Admiral Anderson was referring to one of the naval heroes of the American War of Independence, whose exploits against the British were legendary. McNamara recounts Anderson stating that if the navy was left alone, they would run this blockade successfully as well.

> I rose from my chair and walked out of the room saying this was not a blockade but a means of communication between Kennedy and Khrushchev. No force would be applied without my permission, and that would not be given without discussion with the President. "Was that understood?" I asked. The tight-lipped response was "Yes".

Dialogue constructed from memory inevitably plays a part in any history but assumes a particular significance in the story of the blockade. Such exchanges inevitably display a coherence and logic that real-life exchanges frequently do not (as the Presidential Recordings demonstrate in abundance).

There are other accounts of the exchange in which Secretary McNamara is bested by Admiral Anderson. His deputy, Roswell Gilpatric, was the only other non-naval official present, and while his account generally accords with that of his boss, he recalled how at the end of the exchange, McNamara turned red and left the room.[81]

Yet, at the same time, McNamara (and Kennedy) recognised the need for commanders to protect their ships and crews. As the Secretary of Defense told the National Security Council on 22 October, 'we have to leave it to the local commander. Depending on the seas, and whether there is a submarine in the area, there are just a host of circumstances we've thought of which we don't believe we should try to give orders from here in relation to.'[82]

McNamara's account also suggests that Admiral Anderson seems 'a few turrets short of a battleship,' as the phrase goes. He appeared unfamiliar with some of the basics in running a stop and search blockade. Yet, the navy had been contemplating a blockade of Soviet shipping for months, if not